



Some of the many metrics in a typical analytics report

your Web site), search engines (visits coming from search engines) and Other (online campaigns, newsletters, etc).

Using This Data

Now that the definitions are out of the way, how do you use that data harvested from your tool for your advantage? From the data about page views, visits, pages per visit, bounce rate, average time on site and percentage new visits over a period of time, you can get a picture of whether your site is delivering the goods. For example, if your site has a total of 20 pages, and the pages per visit is something 5.6, this means that less than half of your site gets visited. In relation to this, you can make use of another statistic which indicates the number of visits per page. This combination will show you which sections of your site aren't giving you the desired results. With this information, you can now decide what corrective steps need to be taken. It might also mean that you need to tweak the site's design to make sure that the areas you want people to go to are easily accessible. Google Website Optimizer, a free tool which predicts the change of user data depending on design elements is very useful in this scenario.

This brings us to keywords and traffic sources. Face it: unless your site is very well known, most of your visits are going to come either through search engines or referrals from other sites. Web analytics tools show which keywords have generated the maximum number of visits—this is a very good indicator of what people expect from your site. Add this information to the traffic from other sites, and you have a fair idea of what your visitors come looking for. Accordingly, you have a number of strategies for improving the visibility of your site, starting from SEO and SEM (check out *Get Noticed, Get Clicked*, November 2007) as well as patronising your referral sites. Conversely, if you have invested considerably in a referral site and you find that very few visitors have come through that door, you can terminate the agreement before you spend too much. You might have also launched other Internet publicity campaigns like paid advertising and email newsletters -traffic source statistics are a great way to measure the effectiveness of your campaigns. No matter how insignificant these numbers are, they help provide an insight into customer behaviour.

Tools Of The Trade

Google Analytics, the analytics tool from Google is one of the most well known, and is



Answer the question why your Web site exists, then identify the two or three metrics that are critical to goal conversion."

Avinash Kaushik
Google Analytics Evangelist

widely used. It is suitable for small sites and is integrated with AdWords. However, the free account has certain limitations: it can be used only if your site has less than five million page views per month: if page views exceed five million then it has to be linked to an active AdWords account that has a minimum budget of \$1 (or equivalent). Another commonly used tool to track user statistics—especially on blogs—is StatCounter. This provides rudimentary data like number of visitors over a certain interval: nothing as detailed, or as intimidating as Google Analytics. Microsoft is launching its own analytics package called Gaineau (still in private beta), which will incorporate several new metrics like gender patterns as well. How exactly they plan on finding out visitors' genders, they aren't telling. If you don't mind shelling out the cash, you can use ClickTracks, WebTrends, Omniture, Mint or WebSitStory. All these come in different versions and have a wide range of uses. These tools are more suitable if you host your own site, or have a need of getting customised reports. Mint, for example, provides an installer which has to be downloaded and installed on the server.

At a basic level, the data generated by these tools is self explanatory, but to make sense of that data and make appropriate changes to your site, it takes a professional. Companies who maintain big Web sites have dedicated teams of analysts to monitor the latest trends of visitor behaviour, and help businesses target audiences better. Suvomoy Sarkar, Head of Analytics at Info-edge (which is in charge of Naukri.com's traffic analysis) feels that analysing the search histories of users can tell companies what customers are looking for, while also identifying the most important keywords you should optimise your site for, or the Ad-words you need to buy. "Web Analytics has impacted a many-fold increase in profit from our online marketing efforts, and nearly two-fold increment in the user experience for our search," says Sarkar.

The Bottom Line

Though Web analytics seems to be a forbidden domain with an extremely high learning curve, it's not very difficult to apply some small insights to optimise a Web site. Avinash Kaushik, Google Analytics Evangelist and author of *Web Analytics: An Hour A Day*, opines that even without going deep into technicalities or bellyaching about low unique visitors or hits, there are plenty of things that can be fixed by a cursory look at an analytics report. "Look at the bounce rate for your [promotional] campaigns...and understand which of these campaigns stink. Or look at the bounce rates for your top entry pages.... you'll immediately know which pages are not even engaging enough to get your visitors to make one click." Fix the obvious, is the message, and we couldn't agree more with that. ■

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